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WOMEN CANDIDATES IN ELECTIONS SINCE THE RESERVATION BILL

‘Only 10% of 31,429 poll candidates since 2023 were women’

The Hindu Bureau

NEW DELHI

Since the passage of the Women's Reservation Bill in 2023, Assembly polls have been held in 20 States and Union Territories (UTs). Out of a total of 31,429 candidates who contested in these polls, only 3,273 (10.2%) were women.

The proportion of women candidates did not exceed 14% across these States and Union Territories, according to an analysis by the Association for Democratic Reforms.

The Women's Reservation Bill mandates that 33% seats be reserved for women.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, held months after the passage of the Bill, out of 8,360 candidates analysed, only 800 (9.6%) were women and 152 (28%) in 543 constituencies had

zero women candidates, the report said.

Assemblies which had the highest number of women candidates were Odisha (2024) at 13.9%, Delhi (2025) at 13.7% and Puducherry (2026) at 13.6%. Arunachal Pradesh (2024) and Jammu and Kashmir (2024) recorded the lowest participation, with women constituting only 4.9% of the total candidates.

Benchmark not met

As far as the Lok Sabha polls were concerned, no political party met the one-third (33%) benchmark for women candidates in the 2024 general election.

While the Bharatiya Janata Party and Indian National Congress fielded women candidates in the range of 13%-16%, several State parties recorded substantially higher levels of female representation.

WOMEN CANDIDATES IN ELECTIONS SINCE THE RESERVATION BILL

● Key Data (ADR Analysis)

- Since the Women's Reservation Bill (2023), Assembly polls held in 20 States/UTs
- Out of 31,429 total candidates, only 3,273 (10.2%) were women; share did not exceed 14% in any State/UT

● Lok Sabha 2024 Trends

- Out of 8,360 candidates analysed, only 800 (9.6%) were women
- 152 constituencies (28%) had zero women candidates
- No political party met the one-third (33%) benchmark for women candidates

● Significance

- Highlights the gap between legislative intent (33% seat reservation) and actual candidate-selection practice by parties
- The Reservation Act mandates reserved seats, but ticket distribution by parties remains a separate, unaddressed bottleneck

WOMEN CANDIDATES IN ELECTIONS SINCE THE RESERVATION BILL

Practice Question (PYQ-Style)

With reference to the Women's Reservation Bill (Constitution 106th Amendment Act, 2023), consider the following statements:

- 1. It reserves one-third of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies.**
- 2. The reservation came into effect immediately upon passage in 2023 for all subsequent elections.**
- 3. The Act mandates that political parties nominate at least one-third women candidates in every election.**

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only**
- (b) 1 and 2 only**
- (c) 2 and 3 only**
- (d) 1, 2 and 3**

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Answer

Correct Option: (a) 1 only

Explanation: Statement 2 is incorrect - implementation of the reservation is linked to the delimitation exercise to be carried out after the next Census, so it has not come into effect immediately. Statement 3 is incorrect - the Act reserves seats, but does not impose any legal quota on party-level candidate nomination, which is why women's candidature shares have remained low despite the law.

WOMEN CANDIDATES IN ELECTIONS SINCE THE RESERVATION BILL

Where to Apply

- **Prelims** : Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023; Women's Reservation Bill provisions; Election Commission and political party nomination practices.
- **Mains** : GS Paper 2 (Polity - Women's Representation, Federalism) - 'Gap between legislative reservation and parties' political will in candidate selection.'
- **Interview** : Should there be a separate quota for women within party tickets, distinct from seat reservation? What are the practical challenges in implementing the Women's Reservation Act?

FOR TEACHERS, THE LAST PERIOD NEVER ARRIVES

For teachers, the last period never arrives



ROOPALI SINHA

The problem with this epidemic of perpetual busyness is that teachers are left with no free time or space to read, think, create, or explore new things. Leisure is the condition that makes intellectual life possible

SCHOOLS ARE shut for the summer holidays. Yet for the past few years, a sword has hung over these vacations. There is always the uncertainty that they may be cut short, teachers may be called back, or assigned some new duty. Earlier, summer holidays were one of the incentives of the teaching profession, especially for women balancing home and work. Today, teaching may still be described as a part-time job, but it takes up more time than many full-time ones.

Teachers in both private and government schools return home much like their students, carrying bags full of "homework" — preparing assignments, checking notebooks, filling out report cards, and completing administrative tasks. Work spills into the little "free time" that belongs to their personal lives and families.

The Covid years accelerated this process. Online teaching ensured continuity in children's education. But that connectivity has since become a tool for exploitation. Teachers can be asked at any hour to submit reports, data, or documents, and are expected to comply immediately. The boundaries between the professional and the personal have all but disappeared. Perhaps that is why the old reverence embodied in "Guru Brahma, Guru Vishnu..." now survives largely as a ritual saved for Teachers' Day. In reality, teachers are now marionettes, expected to obey instructions and whims without question.

This becomes particularly visible in the endless non-academic duties assigned to them. Recently, news emerged from Uttar Pradesh's Bareilly that teachers had been assigned the task of collecting fodder. The order was later modified following protests. Such examples are not unusual. Teachers are routinely assigned election duties, Census work, surveys, data-entry campaigns, mid-day meal management, and other such duties. Time that could be spent improving classroom practice or developing professional expertise is consumed by tasks far removed from teaching. In the process, the profession loses its intellectual freedom.

The problem with this epidemic of perpetual busyness is that teachers are left with no free time to read, think, create, or explore new things. Leisure is the condition that makes intellectual life possible. Yet this space for reflection is steadily being taken away from us. I am often reminded of Rabindranath Tagore's poem "Lost Time", though in a context quite different from his spiritual one. Who knows, even Jawaharlal Nehru's "Aaram Haram Hai" slogan may soon be evolved to justify our predicament. That slogan belonged to the years immediately after Independence, when a newly independent nation had to be built. Today, the corporate world's many Narayana Murthys have appropriated it to celebrate endless toil that inflates corporate wealth. It feels almost dystopian to argue for the importance of rest, but that is where we have arrived as a society. People are being reduced to cogs in the machine, valued only for their revenue-generating potential.

Teachers once shaped future citizens by nurturing curiosity, sensitivity, and a sense of responsibility. The work of nation-building may no longer be the urgent task it once was, but in the disappearance of free time, something equally important is ebbing away: The space for reflection, and intellectual and emotional growth. That is an immeasurable loss.

The writer is a Delhi-based teacher

FOR TEACHERS, THE LAST PERIOD NEVER ARRIVES

● Core Issue

- Despite summer holidays, teachers face uncertainty of being recalled or assigned new non-academic duties
- Teaching, once considered flexible 'part-time' work, today consumes more time than many full-time jobs

● Non-Academic Burden

○ Teachers routinely assigned election duties, Census work, surveys, data-entry campaigns and mid-day meal management

- Example: Uttar Pradesh's Bareilly - teachers assigned fodder-collection duty, later modified after protests

● Impact of Technology

- COVID-era online teaching normalised round-the-clock digital availability
- Teachers expected to respond to instructions and data requests at any hour, blurring professional-personal boundaries

● Larger Consequence

- Loss of 'leisure' needed for intellectual growth - reading, thinking, creating and reflecting
- The profession is losing its intellectual freedom; teachers reduced to administrative functionaries

● Way Forward

- Need to ring-fence teachers' academic time from non-teaching government duties
- Protecting teachers' free time is essential to preserve classroom quality and the profession's nation-building role

LOPSIDED SOLUTION: PHARMA REGULATORY OVERSIGHT

Lopsided solution

In India, regulatory oversight for pharmaceuticals needs to improve

As part of an overarching attempt to restore confidence in India's pharmaceutical supply chain after a series of deaths damaged the country's reputation as a drug exporter, the government has required a doctor's prescription for individuals to purchase syrup-based medicines. However, while it seems like a credible measure, it is also defensive rather than reformist. The Union Health Ministry has removed the term "syrup" from Schedule K of the Drugs Rules 1945, a change it had signalled when it issued the draft notification in December 2025, thus requiring cough syrups to be sold only with a prescription, through licensed pharmacies. These products were singled out after ethylene glycol (EG) and diethylene glycol (DEG) contamination in India-made cough syrups killed over 300 children across several countries since 2022. The WHO's warnings in 2022 and 2023 also undermined assumptions that India's export quality controls were effective and functioning independently. But beyond contamination, doctors have long raised concerns about how cough syrups are formulated and used. Many over-the-counter (OTC) cough syrups are 'cocktails' of bronchodilators, antihistamines, and decongestants, which can cause tremors and heart palpitations, extreme sedation or paradoxical agitation in infants, and blood pressure effects. The American Academy of Pediatrics has said that cough suppressants are quite ineffective for children under six years and may even be dangerous, as they can mask underlying conditions such as pneumonia or asthma. Yet, India's entrenched OTC culture makes pharmacists de facto primary care providers in many rural and semi-urban areas.

Most importantly, however, the contamination was the result of failures in manufacturing quality control, testing of raw materials, and regulatory oversight rather than consumer access. Even now, requiring a prescription may reduce inappropriate use and push patients away from self-medication, but it could never prevent contaminated products from reaching the market in the first place. The fundamental issue is that the government continues to tolerate the pharmaceutical lobby's argument that high-end testing requirements – for stronger quality control and ultimately better drugs – will bankrupt smaller manufacturers. Second, while the *Indian Pharmacopoeia* and the *Pharmacopoeia Internationalis* updated their analytical methods to detect EG/DEG following the deaths, failures in batch testing and enforcement persist. As a result, while India has around three dozen State drug controllers, they are chronically understaffed – so without a large increase in the inspectorate, the notification is likely to be ignored sans consequence in rural areas. In a globalised economy, subpar enforcement for medicines in even one country is dangerous; that is infinitely more so in a country aspiring to remain the world's pharmacy.

LOPSIDED SOLUTION: PHARMA REGULATORY OVERSIGHT

● **Background**

- Government mandates a doctor's prescription for syrup-based medicines after deaths linked to contaminated cough syrups
- Union Health Ministry removed the term 'syrup' from Schedule K of the Drugs Rules, 1945, requiring sale only through licensed pharmacies with a prescription

● **Cause of the Crisis**

- Ethylene Glycol (EG) and Diethylene Glycol (DEG) contamination in India-made cough syrups killed over 300 children across countries since 2022
- WHO issued warnings in 2022 and 2023 on India's export quality controls

● **Clinical Concerns with OTC Syrups**

- Many OTC cough syrups are 'cocktails' of bronchodilators, antihistamines and decongestants - risk of tremors, sedation and blood-pressure effects in infants
- American Academy of Pediatrics: cough suppressants are largely ineffective and potentially dangerous for children under six

● **Critique of the Government's Response**

- **The prescription mandate is defensive, not reformist - it addresses consumer access, not manufacturing and testing failures**
- **The real issue is failures in raw-material testing, batch quality control and regulatory oversight, not patient access**
- **India has only about three dozen State Drug Controllers, who are chronically understaffed, weakening enforcement in rural areas**

● **Way Forward**

- **Strengthen inspectorate capacity and enforce updated Indian Pharmacopoeia and Pharmacopoeia Internationalis testing standards**
- **Address the pharmaceutical lobby's resistance to high-end testing requirements for smaller manufacturers**

IS INDIA PRODUCING MORE GRADUATES THAN THE ECONOMY CAN ABSORB?

Is India producing more graduates than what the economy can absorb?



Rajan Wadhwa
Former President, Automotive Sector, Mahindra & Mahindra

PARLEY

India is witnessing an unprecedented expansion in higher education. Over the past decade, thousands of new colleges and universities have been established, producing millions of graduates every year. Yet unemployment of the educated remains a growing concern. Nearly one in three graduates are unemployed. Is India producing more graduates than what the economy can absorb? Rajan Wadhwa and O.R.S. Rao discuss the question in a conversation moderated by M. Kalyanaraman. Edited excerpts:

Is India producing more graduates than the economy can absorb?



O.R.S. Rao
Chancellor, ICFAI University, Sikkim

O.R.S. Rao: The numbers point to a widening gap between the growth in graduates and the growth in jobs. In engineering alone, the number of graduates has risen sharply over the past few years while job creation has not kept pace. Earlier, the IT services sector was the principal employer of engineering graduates. Today, hiring by IT services firms has slowed considerably, even though sectors such as banking and financial services, manufacturing, defence and space technologies have expanded their recruitment. The challenge is that these new opportunities have not grown fast enough to absorb the increasing number of graduates entering the labour market.

A second issue is the nature of investment. Much of the recent investment in sectors such as semiconductors, advanced manufacturing and technology has been capital-intensive rather than labour-intensive. As a result, large investments do not necessarily translate into proportionate job creation.

Has AI made the problem worse?

ORSR: We are in the middle of a major technological transition. AI is changing the nature of work much faster than how educational institutions can adapt. Companies now want graduates who can work with AI systems, validate AI-generated outputs, understand responsible and ethical AI use, and solve complex problems using technology. Four years ago, when many of today's graduates entered college, these skills were not widely discussed. Universities cannot redesign programmes overnight, and students cannot acquire entirely new competencies instantly.

As a result, many graduates are entering the labour market that demands skills different from those they were trained for.

Is employability more important than just



Keeping up: Candidates who came for a mega job fair at the Government Engineering College in Thrissur in 2025. NAEIB A.K.

job creation?

Rajan Wadhwa: There is certainly a growing concern about employability, particularly among engineering graduates. The problem is often a mismatch between what is taught and what the industry requires. Students may graduate with strong academic credentials but have limited exposure to laboratories, manufacturing environments, teamwork and real-world problem-solving. When they enter the industry, employers frequently find that they need substantial additional training in order to contribute effectively. Companies run their own training programmes to bridge this gap. This was far less common a few decades ago.

Has manufacturing failed to create enough opportunities?

RW: Manufacturing still has considerable potential, but it too is undergoing profound change. People often focus on the impact of AI on software jobs, but manufacturing is also being transformed by automation, robotics, and Industry 4.0 systems. Historically, a large number of engineers were employed in supervisory and operational roles on factory floors. Today, many of those functions are automated. Digital manufacturing systems require fewer people to oversee production processes. As a result, the number of engineering jobs generated by manufacturing is not increasing at the pace many people expected. Even as factories expand output, they often require fewer workers and supervisors than before.

Does that mean the future is one of permanent jobless growth?

RW: I would not go that far. India's push towards self-reliance in sectors such as defence,



Students may graduate with strong academic credentials but have limited exposure to laboratories, manufacturing environments, teamwork and real-world problem-solving

RAJAN WADHWA

aerospace and advanced manufacturing is creating new opportunities. There is increasing emphasis on domestic design and product development, and that is encouraging. The challenge is that automation and digitalisation are reducing labour requirements even as industries grow. Therefore, employment growth may not automatically match economic growth. This makes it even more important for educational institutions and industry to work together. Curricula needs to be aligned much more closely with industry requirements.

Has India focused too much on manufacturing and too little on innovation?

ORSR: Over many years, India became increasingly proficient at manufacturing products designed elsewhere; manufacturing alone does not create enough opportunities for highly trained engineers. The real value lies in research, development and design. Countries that control intellectual property and technology create far more opportunities for engineers than countries that simply manufacture products. Recent global developments have reinforced this lesson. Increasing restrictions on access to critical technologies such as semiconductors and strategic components have shown that excessive dependence on external technologies carries risks. India therefore needs to invest much more aggressively in indigenous research, innovation and product development.

Has India made progress in indigenous design capabilities?

RW: It would be incorrect to say that India remains only a manufacturing base. Over the last decade, companies such as Mahindra and Tata Motors have developed significant design and engineering capabilities. Indian engineers today are designing vehicles, platforms, transmissions and other complex systems that would previously have been developed elsewhere. The issue is scale. The number of high-quality engineering graduates being produced is larger than the number of advanced R&D and design roles currently available.

What role should entrepreneurship play?

ORSR: Neither government nor industry can create enough jobs for every graduate. We need more graduates to become creators of enterprises rather than only seekers of employment. One major challenge is access to risk capital. Traditional lenders prefer established businesses and proven revenue streams. Innovation, however, requires investors willing to support ideas at an early stage. India's startup ecosystem has made significant progress, but much more needs to be done to support deep-technology ventures.

What should India focus on in the AI era?

ORSR: India should focus not only on infrastructure but also on products. There is a significant need for sovereign AI as nations with these systems seek to restrict access. Product companies create intellectual property, innovation and high-value employment. The goal should be to develop products not only for India but for global markets. We should identify strategic areas where India can become a global leader. UPI's success demonstrates that India is capable of building world-class digital platforms.

What needs to change in higher education?

ORSR: Industry-academia collaboration must become much deeper. Universities cannot design relevant programmes without industry participation, and industry cannot expect job-ready graduates without contributing to curriculum, internships and skill development.

Looking ahead, what are the priorities?

ORSR: Three priorities stand out. First, India must significantly increase investment in research and development. Second, industry and academia must work together much more closely. Third, we need a stronger entrepreneurship ecosystem that encourages innovation and supports risk-taking.

RW: I would add that India must continue building indigenous capabilities in design, engineering and advanced manufacturing. The opportunities are real, particularly in sectors such as defence and aerospace. The challenge is ensuring that education, industry and policy move in the same direction.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

IS INDIA PRODUCING MORE GRADUATES THAN THE ECONOMY CAN ABSORB?

● **Core Concern**

- Nearly one in three graduates in India remains unemployed despite an unprecedented expansion of higher education
- There is a widening gap between the growth in the number of graduates and the growth in job creation

● **Sectoral Shift**

- IT services, the principal employer of engineering graduates, have slowed hiring; banking, manufacturing, defence and space sectors are expanding recruitment but not fast enough
- **Recent investment in semiconductors, advanced manufacturing and technology is capital-intensive rather than labour-intensive**

● **Skills Mismatch**

- Employers find that graduates need substantial additional training; companies now run their own training programmes to bridge this gap
- Limited student exposure to laboratories, manufacturing environments, teamwork and real-world problem-solving

● **Role of AI and Automation**

- AI is reshaping job requirements faster than educational institutions can adapt their curricula
- Automation and Industry 4.0 are reducing labour requirements even as manufacturing output grows, so employment growth may not match economic growth

● **Suggested Reforms**

- Deeper industry-academia collaboration in curriculum design, internships and skill development
- Greater investment in R&D, innovation and indigenous design capability, not just manufacturing capacity
- A stronger entrepreneurship ecosystem and better access to risk capital, so graduates become job creators, not only job seekers

IAS OFFICER ARRESTED IN RS.79 CR IDFC BANK SCAM

IAS officer arrested in Rs 79 cr IDFC Bank scam

Express News Service
Chandigarh, June 18

THE CENTRAL Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Thursday arrested senior IAS officer Ram Kumar Singh, former Commissioner of the Municipal Corporation (MC), Panchkula, in connection with the alleged misappropriation of government funds worth Rs 79.46 crore from the civic body's account maintained at the Sector 32 branch of IDFC First Bank in Chandigarh. Singh was placed under suspension on April 9.

The arrest is a significant development in the investigation into what has emerged as one of Haryana's biggest financial frauds, involving the alleged siphoning of more than Rs 504 crore belonging to multiple government departments through forged and non-existent fixed deposits.

According to the CBI, the Municipal Corporation Panchkula account was opened in vi-

olation of Haryana Finance Department guidelines and allegedly facilitated fraudulent transactions. The agency alleged that Singh, while serving as MC Commissioner, entered into a criminal conspiracy with officials of IDFC First Bank and handed over multiple signed cheques through intermediaries on the pretext of creating fixed deposits which weren't created. Instead, the funds were allegedly withdrawn and diverted to shell companies controlled by the accused bank officials.

Searches were conducted at Singh's residences in Chandigarh and Karnal, and several incriminating documents were recovered. The CBI took over the investigation from the Haryana State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau. The agency has chargesheeted 17 accused in the Haryana-linked scam, including six officials of IDFC First Bank and AU Small Finance Bank, three Haryana government officials and others.

IAS OFFICER ARRESTED IN RS.79 CR IDFC BANK SCAM

● Key Event

○ CBI arrested senior IAS officer Ram Kumar Singh, former Commissioner of the Municipal Corporation, Panchkula, in a Rs.79.46 crore fund misappropriation case

- Funds were from the civic body's account at IDFC First Bank, Chandigarh; Singh was placed under suspension on April 9

● Modus Operandi Alleged

- Entered into criminal conspiracy with bank officials and handed over signed cheques through intermediaries on the pretext of creating fixed deposits that were never created
- Funds were allegedly withdrawn and diverted to shell companies controlled by the accused bank officials

● Scale of the Scam

- Part of a larger Rs.504 crore Haryana-linked financial fraud involving forged and non-existent fixed deposits across multiple government departments
- CBI has chargesheeted 17 accused, including bank officials and Haryana government officials
- Investigation taken over by the CBI from the Haryana State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau

● Ethical and Governance Dimensions

- Represents a breach of public trust and probity in public service by a senior civil servant
- Indicates violation of Haryana Finance Department guidelines and a failure of internal financial controls in urban local bodies
- Highlights the need for robust accountability mechanisms, internal audit and whistleblower protection in municipal finance

TELEGRAM EVOLVED INTO THE 'NEW DARK WEB': GOVT VS PLATFORM

Telegram evolved into 'new dark web', govt. tells Delhi HC

Govt. says the app is used by cybercriminals, exam paper leak operators; court questions the platform-wide ban as it hears Telegram's challenge

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Union government on Thursday submitted before the Delhi High Court that the messaging platform Telegram had evolved into the "new dark web", arguing that its architecture and privacy features had made it a preferred tool for cybercriminals, fraud networks, extremist and terror groups, and operators involved in examination paper leaks.

The government's submissions relied heavily on an Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) assessment that the platform was a growing hub for illicit online activity. The government has restricted access to the platform

Telegram on trial

The messaging platform contests restrictions imposed under Section 69A of the IT Act



Govt.'s stand

- Used by cybercriminals, fraud networks, extremist groups, and exam leak operators
- Fails to act against illegal and suspicious channels despite repeated requests
- Features can be misused to falsely portray exam papers as leaked and trigger law-and-order concerns

Telegram's stand

- Centre fails to justify emergency powers or a platform-wide ban
- Specific content can be blocked instead of restricting the entire platform

ahead of the June 21 NEET re-examination.

Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre during the hearing on Telegram's petition challenging the temporary ban imposed till June 22 under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act, 2000, told the court

that the enterprise behind the messaging app had been repeatedly asked to proactively monitor and curb illegal and suspicious channels on the platform.

CONTINUED ON

» PAGE 10

ON SECTION 69A

» PAGE 10

Telegram evolved into 'new dark web': govt.

However, the company failed to take any meaningful action, Mr. Mehta said.

Senior advocate Dhruv Mehta, appearing for Telegram, said the government had failed to justify the use of emergency powers and had not demonstrated why specific content could not be blocked, instead of disabling access to the entire platform. "The order says it is in the interest of the sovereignty and integrity of India. An examination like NEET will affect the sovereignty and integrity of India?" he asked.

A Bench of Justice Tejas Kataria scrutinised the government's justification for a platform-wide restriction, even as it acknowledged concerns about exam malpractice and cybercrime. "How can we stop the rights of 150 million people just because one set of citizens are appearing in examinations?" he said while hearing submissions from both sides.

The judgment has been reserved for Friday.

The Centre's affidavit also details how Telegram is allegedly used by cyber threat actors to coordinate attacks, distribute malware, and facilitate financial crime. It is alleged that Telegram channels host marketplaces for rented and mule bank accounts used in money laundering and cyber fraud. Such channels enable criminals to exchange information on bank accounts, UPI handles, and cryptocurrency conversion mechanisms while, due to the interface, it remains difficult for the police to track them because new channels emerge continuously.

"The entire population of a channel, around a lakh, can be moved to another channel in seconds. This is unique to Telegram and poses a serious risk," the Solicitor General said.

To support its claims, the Centre pointed to a sharp rise in cybercrime complaints linked to Telegram. Data placed before the court show that complaints on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal involving Telegram increased from 75,688 in 2023 to 2.75 lakh in 2025, with reported fraud amounts crossing ₹3,000 crore in 2025. In 2026, by May, over 88,000 such complaints had already been recorded.

"In Telegram, one account can create 40 bots. In WhatsApp it's one bot per user," Mr. Mehta said.

TELEGRAM EVOLVED INTO THE 'NEW DARK WEB': GOVT VS PLATFORM

● Background of the Case

- Centre told the Delhi High Court that Telegram has evolved into the 'new dark web', used by cybercriminals, fraud networks, extremist/terror groups and exam-paper-leak operators
- Government's submissions relied on an **Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) assessment**
- A temporary ban was imposed till June 22 under Section 69A of the IT Act, 2000, heard by a Bench of Justice Tejas Kataria

● Government's Stand

- Telegram fails to act against illegal and suspicious channels despite repeated requests; features are misused to falsely claim exam papers have leaked, relevant ahead of the June 21 NEET re-examination
- Cybercrime complaints linked to Telegram rose from 75,688 (2023) to 2.75 lakh (2025); fraud crossed Rs.3,000 crore in 2025, with 88,000+ complaints by May 2026
- A channel of about 1 lakh members can be moved to a new channel in seconds; one account can create 40 bots, versus one bot per user on WhatsApp

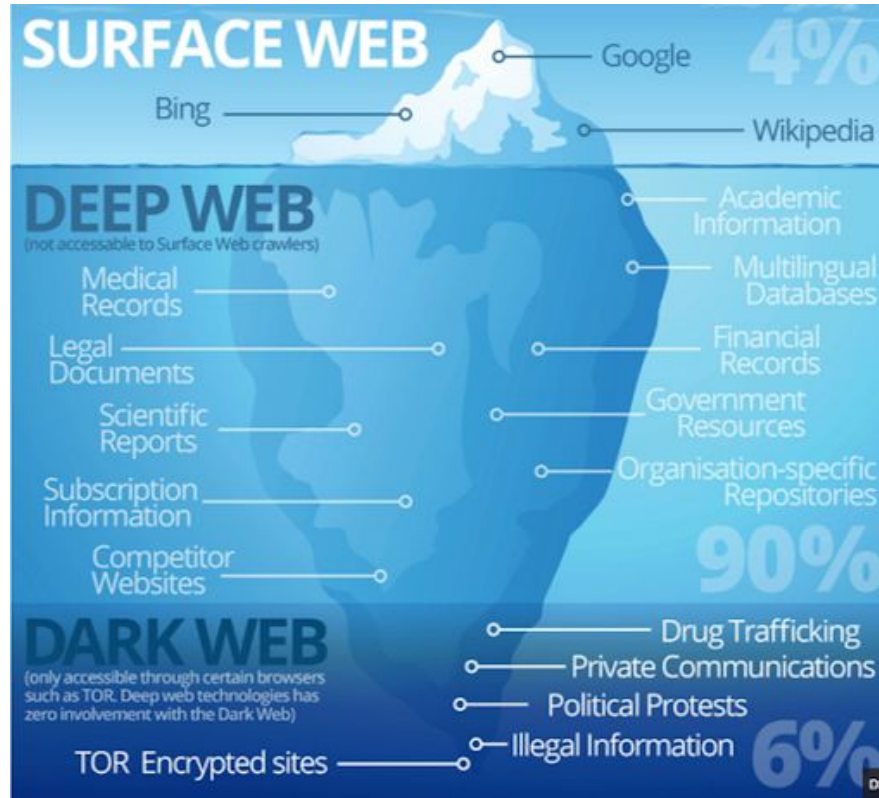
● Telegram's Stand

- The Centre failed to justify the use of emergency powers or a platform-wide ban
- Specific illegal content can be blocked instead of restricting access to the entire platform

● Court's Observations

- **The Bench questioned proportionality, asking how the rights of 150 million users could be curtailed for one set of citizens appearing in examinations**
- **Judgment reserved, balancing exam-malpractice and cybercrime concerns against the impact of a blanket platform ban**

Dark Web



Thank You